

INTERVIEW GUIDE & STRATEGIC SYNTHESIS

Desk Research → Live Research Transition

Purpose: Translates findings from the desk research phase into actionable tools for live qualitative interviews with practitioners. Includes a strategic memo summarizing the most promising areas for deeper investigation, a modular interview guide, and a screening framework for participant selection.

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PART 1: STRATEGIC SYNTHESIS MEMO

Where the Research Points — Summary for Product & Strategy

To: [Client / Project Lead]

From: [Researcher Name]

Re: Desk Research Findings — Recommended Focus Areas for Live Interviews

After systematically reviewing 300+ public sources across 7 business functions, three areas emerge as the strongest candidates for deeper investigation and potential product intervention. These are ranked by a combination of: Frequency, Severity, Cross-functional relevance, and Automation potential.

Recommended Focus Area 1: Cross-Departmental Handoffs and Status Tracking

Why this is the top priority: This is the single most consistent source of operational friction across all functions researched. Every function described waiting on, chasing, or manually coordinating with other teams. The common element is that these handoffs happen through unstructured channels (email, Slack, verbal) with no workflow layer providing visibility, accountability, or structured inputs.

What we need to learn in live interviews:

- How do practitioners currently track what they're waiting on from other teams?
- What triggers the 'chase' behavior — is it calendar-based, deadline-based, or reactive?
- Have they tried any tools or processes to formalize cross-departmental handoffs? What happened?
- What would 'good enough' look like — do they need full workflow automation or just visibility?

Hypothesis to test: *Companies would adopt a lightweight handoff tool that sits between email and full workflow software — something that creates structured requests with status tracking without requiring the other department to adopt a new tool.*

Recommended Focus Area 2: Shadow Tracking Systems (The Universal Spreadsheet)

Why this matters: Every function researched maintains at least one critical workflow in a personal spreadsheet outside the official system. This is a symptom of tools that don't match how work actually flows. The spreadsheet represents both the pain (fragile, invisible, person-dependent) and the solution blueprint (it shows exactly what information practitioners need to track).

What we need to learn in live interviews:

- Can we see the actual spreadsheet? (Most valuable research artifact possible)
- What information is in the spreadsheet that isn't in their official tools?
- How often is it updated? Is it shared or personal?
- What would make them stop using it?

Hypothesis to test: *The gap between official tools and shadow spreadsheets reveals specific feature gaps that, if addressed, would allow practitioners to work within their primary systems instead of maintaining parallel tracking.*

Recommended Focus Area 3: Reconciliation and Matching Workflows

Why this is promising: Reconciliation work is highly structured, rule-based, and repetitive — ideal characteristics for automation. It also represents the single largest time block in the month-end close (2-5 days of a 10-15 day close). Current automation tools (BlackLine, etc.) are priced for enterprise, leaving mid-market companies with manual processes.

What we need to learn in live interviews:

- Walk me through one specific reconciliation from start to finish
- What percentage of line items match automatically vs. require investigation?
- What are the most common reasons for mismatches?
- What's the current cost in time and headcount?

Hypothesis to test: *A reconciliation tool priced for mid-market companies (vs. enterprise) that handles the 80% of straightforward matching while flagging the 20% of exceptions would reduce reconciliation time by 60-70%.*

PART 2: MODULAR INTERVIEW GUIDE

Interview Design Philosophy

These interviews should feel like peer conversations, not interrogations. The goal is to get practitioners to walk you through their actual work — screen-share if possible, show the spreadsheet, demonstrate the workaround. Abstract questions get abstract answers. Specific, grounded questions get actionable insights.

Interview Structure (90 minutes recommended)

Phase	Duration	Purpose	Energy Level
Warm-Up & Context	10 min	Build rapport, understand role and company	Low-stakes
Workflow Walkthrough	25 min	Map the actual process as they do it	High engagement
Pain Point Deep Dive	25 min	Explore specific friction points from desk research	Peak focus
Tool & Workaround Audit	15 min	Understand current tool landscape and shadow systems	Moderate
Ideal State & Priorities	10 min	What would 'better' look like?	Forward-looking
Wrap-Up	5 min	Anything missed, referrals, next steps	Wind-down

Module A: Warm-Up & Context (10 minutes)

Goal: Understand the person, their role, and their company context. Don't jump into pain points yet.

1. Tell me about your role. What does a typical week look like for you?
Probe: What percentage of your time is routine/recurring vs. ad hoc?
2. How big is your team? Who do you work with most closely outside your team?
3. What tools do you use every day? (Don't prompt with specific names — let them volunteer)
Probe: Which ones do you actually like using? Which ones feel like a chore?

Module B: Workflow Walkthrough (25 minutes)

Goal: Map one specific workflow in detail. For finance roles, this should be the month-end close. For other roles, pick their most recurring cross-functional workflow.

1. Walk me through [the close / your most recurring workflow] from start to finish. Pretend I'm a new hire shadowing you.
Probe: What's the very first thing you do? Then what?
Probe: Where does the information come from? Where does it go next?
2. How long does this process typically take? What's the fastest it's ever been? The slowest?
Probe: What made the difference between fast and slow?
3. If you could point to the one step that causes the most frustration or delay, which would it be?
4. Are there steps that you do every time that aren't written down anywhere?
Probe: If you were out sick, could someone else do this from your documentation alone?

Module C: Pain Point Deep Dive (25 minutes)

Goal: Validate and deepen specific patterns identified in desk research. Pick 2-3 based on participant's role.

For Finance roles — Probe on reconciliation:

1. How do you currently do [bank / intercompany / subledger] reconciliations?
Probe: Can you show me the spreadsheet or template you use?
2. What percentage of items match cleanly vs. require investigation?
3. How do you handle the exceptions — the items that don't match?
Probe: Is there a standard process, or is it case-by-case?
4. Have you evaluated any automation tools for this? What happened?

For any role — Probe on cross-departmental handoffs:

1. What information do you regularly need from other teams to do your job?
2. How do you request it? How do they send it?

Probe: Is it the same format every time? Who decides the format?

3. What happens when it's late or incomplete?

Probe: How often does that happen? What's the impact?

4. Have you tried to formalize this handoff? What worked or didn't?

For any role — Probe on shadow systems:

1. Do you maintain any personal spreadsheets or trackers that aren't part of your official tools?

Probe: Can you show me? (This is gold — the spreadsheet IS the requirements document)

2. What information is in there that isn't in your official systems?

3. How often do you update it? Does anyone else use it?

4. If your official tool could do what this spreadsheet does, would you stop using it?

Probe: What specifically would it need to do?

Module D: Tool & Workaround Audit (15 minutes)

Goal: Map the actual tool landscape and identify gaps between tools and workflows.

1. If you had to list every tool you touch during [the close / your main workflow], what would be on the list?

Probe: For each tool — what do you use it for, and what does it NOT do that you wish it did?

2. Are there any tools your company pays for that you've stopped using or use minimally?

Probe: Why? What replaced it?

3. Do you copy-paste data between tools? How often?

Probe: Walk me through a specific example.

4. If you could magically connect any two tools that don't currently talk to each other, which would you choose?

Module E: Ideal State & Priorities (10 minutes)

Goal: Understand what 'better' means to this person — not abstract product vision, but grounded improvement.

1. If you could wave a magic wand and fix one thing about your workflow, what would it be?

2. What would you do with the time you'd save?

Probe: Is the pain point about time, stress, risk, or something else?

3. Have you ever seen a tool or process at another company that made you jealous?

4. If I came back in 6 months with a solution, how would you know it was working?

Probe: What metric or feeling would tell you things are better?

PART 3: PARTICIPANT SCREENING & RECRUITMENT FRAMEWORK

Based on the desk research, the following participant profiles will yield the richest interview data:

Tier 1 — Highest Priority

Role	Why	Company Size	Key Topics
Controller / Senior Accountant	Owns the month-end close workflow end-to-end; highest exposure to handoff friction and shadow systems	50-300 employees	Close process, checklist, reconciliation, cross-dept dependencies
IT Operations Manager / Senior Sysadmin	Owns onboarding/offboarding workflow; cross-functional by nature; acute pain around employee lifecycle	100-500 employees	Onboarding/offboarding, access management, shadow scripts, license management
Customer Success Manager (mid-market B2B SaaS)	Daily tool fragmentation; rich shadow systems; clear articulation of pain	N/A (role-specific)	Context fragmentation, health scores, renewal prep, handoff from sales

Tier 2 — High Priority

Role	Why	Company Size	Key Topics
Sales Operations Manager / Analyst	Owns quote-to-close workflow; CRM data quality; commission calculation	100-500 employees	CRM hygiene, commission calculation, quote-to-contract, forecasting
HR Operations / People Ops Manager	Owns employee lifecycle processes; cross-functional coordination	100-500 employees	Onboarding, offboarding, status changes, benefits enrollment
Procurement Manager / Buyer	Owns purchasing workflow; PO management; vendor coordination	50-500 employees	PO workflow, approval chains, vendor management, exception handling

Tier 3 — Supplementary

Role	Why	Company Size	Key Topics
Legal Operations Manager	Contract lifecycle; review queue management	200+ employees	Contract tracking, review prioritization, renewal tracking
Operations Manager (manufacturing, distribution, logistics)	ERP exception handling; inventory reconciliation	50-300 employees	ERP workarounds, exception handling, shadow tracking

Screening Questions for Recruitment

1. What is your current role and how long have you been in it? *(Filter for 1+ year tenure — need enough experience to describe real workflows, not just onboarding confusion)*
2. How many people are on your team? *(Filter for 2-20 — too small means one person does everything; too large means specialized roles may not see the full workflow)*
3. Do you use any spreadsheets or personal tracking systems outside your company's main tools to manage your work? *(Filter for yes — these participants will have the richest insights about shadow systems and tool gaps)*
4. Is there a recurring process in your role that you'd describe as "more painful than it should be"? *(Filter for specific, articulate answers — participants who can describe pain concretely will be the best interviewees)*

Screening Criteria

Criteria	Ideal	Acceptable	Exclude
Company Size	50-300 employees	20-500 employees	Under 20 or over 1,000
Role	Controller, Sr. Accountant, CS Manager, IT Admin, Sales Ops	FP&A, HR Ops, Legal Ops, Procurement	C-suite (too removed), Junior staff (too narrow)
Close Timeline	8-15 business days	5-20 business days	Under 5 (already optimized) or over 20
ERP	NetSuite, Sage Intacct, QBO Enterprise	Any mid-market ERP	No ERP or SAP/Oracle (enterprise)
Willingness	Screen-share, show actual tools	Phone interview only	Unwilling to discuss specifics

Recommended Sample

Segment	Target Count	Rationale
Finance — Controller/Sr. Accountant	3-4	Primary research focus; month-end close expertise
Customer Success — CSM/Manager	2	Cross-functional handoff validation
IT Operations — Admin/Manager	1-2	Onboarding/offboarding workflow; tool provisioning
Sales Operations — Ops Manager/Analyst	1-2	CRM data quality; commission workflows

PART 4: RESEARCH PHASE INTEGRATION MAP

This diagram shows how the three research documents work together as a cohesive portfolio:

DOCUMENT 1 Deep Dive Report	DOCUMENT 2 Pain Point Database	DOCUMENT 3 Interview Guide & Strategy
Deep qualitative research on ONE workflow (month-end close) <i>Shows depth of analysis</i>	Structured cross-functional pattern database (40 pain points, 7 functions) <i>Shows breadth and pattern recognition</i>	Strategic memo with hypotheses to test, modular interview guide, screening framework <i>Shows strategic thinking and actionability</i>
DEMONSTRATES: ✓ Source diversity ✓ Critical reading ✓ Deep synthesis ✓ Quote extraction ✓ Structured output	DEMONSTRATES: ✓ Pattern recognition ✓ Taxonomy development ✓ Cross-functional thinking ✓ Prioritization ✓ Clear data organization	DEMONSTRATES: ✓ Research → action ✓ Interview design ✓ Strategic framing ✓ Participant selection ✓ Hypothesis generation

These three documents together demonstrate the full arc of what the client is hiring for: finding signal in noise → organizing it into patterns → translating it into strategic action.

RESEARCH OPERATIONS CHECKLIST

Pre-Interview Preparation

- Review participant's LinkedIn for role context and tenure
- Prepare role-specific module selection (Modules A-E, choose which C probes to use)
- Test recording software and screen-share capability
- Prepare consent form (verbal consent to record at minimum)
- Have the desk research findings printed/available for reference during interview

During Interview

- Record (with permission) — don't rely on notes alone
- Note timestamps when participant mentions specific tools, shows spreadsheets, or describes workarounds
- Ask to see actual screens/documents whenever possible
- Don't correct or suggest solutions — observe and probe
- Capture exact language — their words are more valuable than your paraphrase

Post-Interview Processing

- Complete the debrief template within 24 hours
- Tag findings against friction taxonomy (MH, TF, SS, AB, EH, KC, FT, TS, DE)
- Flag any new patterns not in the desk research
- Update the confidence scores on existing patterns
- Identify the top 2-3 "quotable moments" — specific, vivid descriptions of friction

Debrief Template

Field	Content
Participant ID	[P-001]
Role	[Title]
Company Size	[Employees]
Industry	[Industry]
Close Timeline	[X business days]
Top 3 Pain Points Confirmed	[From desk research patterns]
New Pain Points Discovered	[Not in desk research]
Most Valuable Moment	[Timestamp and description]
Shadow Systems Identified	[What spreadsheets/trackers did they show?]
Tool Landscape	[List of tools mentioned]

Recommended Follow-Up	[Any needed clarification or second session]
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APPENDIX: SYNTHESIS FRAMEWORK

After completing 5+ interviews, compile findings using this framework:

Confidence Update Matrix

Pattern	Pre-Interview Confidence	Post-Interview Confidence	Key Evidence
Checklist Fragmentation	0.85 (high frequency)	[Update after interviews]	[Specific interview evidence]
Cross-Dept Bottlenecks	0.80	[Update after interviews]	[Specific interview evidence]
Manual Reconciliation	0.75	[Update after interviews]	[Specific interview evidence]
Last Mile Reporting	0.65	[Update after interviews]	[Specific interview evidence]
Knowledge Concentration	0.60	[Update after interviews]	[Specific interview evidence]

Final Deliverable: After live interviews, produce a combined research report that integrates desk research patterns with interview validation, updating confidence levels and adding depth from practitioner conversations.